India’ endeavours are attacked by them while ostensibly expressing concern at the trade imbalance with China. The combination of politics, policies and populism lowered our national guard and still continues to target our national morale. Not surprisingly, this is about as far as we can be from the traditions of realism.

In the years that have passed, the Nehru–Patel dichotomy of approaches has continued within the Indian system. It finds resonance in each era through the issues of the day, from the boundary question and border areas management to FTAs and technology issues. Not all of the debate is restricted to its bilateral format. Understandably, given the influence of the two countries, it spills over into the global arena just as easily. Issues like connectivity, debt, development and maritime claims have also become contentious. Overall, there is no question that many of them today are being approached with a higher degree of thought about their implications. The era when Indian policymakers were sanguine about the ‘String of Pearls’ did finally end in 2014.

But there is also a fundamental issue of defining national interests clearly, defending them vigorously and appreciating the nature of power. Asian or even developing world solidarity may have its place, but it was never enough to counter the competitive instincts of a neighbour. Indeed, it is this kernel of the 1950 debate that continues to be relevant.

Today, there are animated conversations across the world on how best to engage China. Naturally, this is even more intense in India, given our proximity as well as the border events of 2020 and thereafter. Polemical positions within India may be driven by political tactics; it is the underlying policies and actions that speak for actual thinking. The true stance of various political forces vis-à-vis China is not episodic, whatever may be the temporary posture. The realists among them hold a worldview that stresses building national capabilities, which puts key concerns like terrorism firmly on the table, calls out actions on unsustainable debt and opaque connectivity, and approaches global developments with national security foremost in mind. It is precisely this approach that will push for upgrading the boundary infrastructure, as it has after 2014. In addition, they would deploy an Indian 5G stack, understand the value of critical and emerging technologies, and, not least, seek from the turbulence of our current era better solutions for our advancement.